once upon a time…

grandma was turning 80, and it was a surprise.

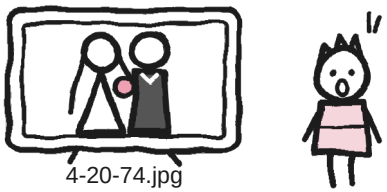


the grandkid scanned a shoebox of old photos for a slideshow, to show grandma her whole life, from the very beginning.

the frame would put them in order. sort of.

letter by letter

that night, the grandkid watched it alone. the frame read each file name one letter at a time, left to right, and never wondered what they meant.



the wedding (**4-20-74**) came before baby grandma (**6-12-46**), because 4 comes before 6.

grandma got married before she was born.

the dog grows young

“put the biggest thing first,” said the grandkid. “the year!”



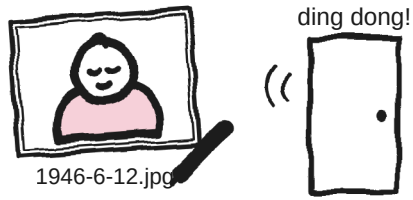
now the old dog (**03-10-9**) came first, and the puppy (**90-3-15**) came last.

the old dog turned into a puppy.

(lucky dog.)

the long way

“the frame doesn't know 03 means 2003,” said the grandkid, and wrote every year the long way: **1946**, **2003**.

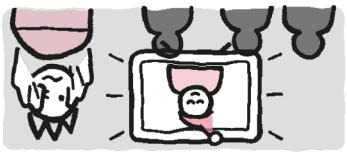


baby grandma moved up, almost to the front. then the doorbell rang.

no time to check again.

surprise!

the lights went down. first slide: a baby in a santa hat. second slide: that same baby, being born.

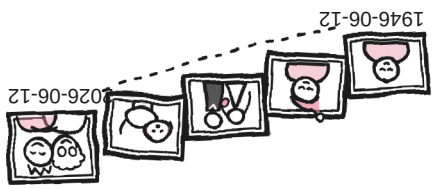


(**1946-12-25** beat **1946-6-12**. 1 comes before 6.) “she always said she was ahead of her time,” said grandpa. everyone laughed, even grandma. the grandkid didn't.

this was not the beginning.

a few little zeros

the grandkid slipped over and gave every month and day two digits: **1946-06-12**.



the slideshow started again. baby grandma. her first christmas. the wedding. mom. the puppy. the old dog. the grandkid.

grandma cried. the good kind.

the moral

biggest first, and everything falls into place.

write dates year-month-day, with the whole year and two digits for the rest. anything that reads left to right sorts them right: you, a photo frame, a folder on your computer.

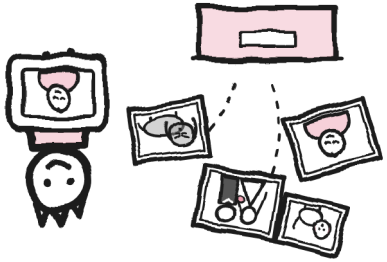
try it: name your next file **2026-10-30-something**, then sort the folder.

(grandpa still says she's ahead of her time.)

BEGINNING

from the very

a birthday slideshow



a story about putting things in order

cut along the dashes